That was Nantie, though – a bit of a nutter. And when you combine his ability to bowl a cricket ball seriously quickly with his personality, things tend to get interesting. Nantie loved to toss in the odd head-high beemer just to perk up the proceedings. Once, during a domestic game at Newlands, he bowled a beemer at me. It came straight for my helmet, but I managed to fend it off. It really pissed me off. I swore like a trooper and warned him not to try any more of that nonsense on me or I'd hit him. He apologised, saying the ball had slipped out of his hand. That was the funny thing about Nantie – for all his apparent aggro, he often backed down when confronted. I don't think it's because he's gutless – it's more to do with his unwillingness to unleash his true craziness. I think if Nantie actually had to genuinely lose his temper, there would be carnage. Breaking-news-on-CNN kind of carnage.

One thing's for sure about Nantie: he didn't like being on the receiving end of a fast bowler's wrath. On that tour, he and Makhaya Ntini were the two tail-enders, trying to dodge bullets from Aussie paceman Brett 'Binga' Lee. Binga was trying his best to hit Nantie, but Nantie was backing so far away to square leg that he was practically standing on the umpire's toes. Makhaya, on the other hand, was standing his ground and, even though he couldn't bat to save his life back then, he wouldn't budge. Binga hit him a few times too. Twice in a row. Unable to duck out of the way, Makhaya just dropped his chin and got klapped flush on the badge of his helmet.

It's funny how the quickest bowlers in the world don't mind bowling – or even throwing – in a few short ones, but when it's their turn to bat, they don't want to stand in the firing line.

But back to me in the nets in Adelaide. Graeme Pollock was sitting on the bench next to the net and, after I had finished my 15-minute session, miraculously escaping both injury and embarrassment, I walked past him. All he said was, 'Looking good, Hersch. You're really hitting the ball well.' I could barely muster a 'Thanks, Graeme' before hotfooting it back to the dressing room for one last vomit.

So ja, that was the downside of being a member of the infamous 'Two Days Before Club'. That morning at the Adelaide Oval was easily the worst I've ever felt on a cricket pitch. Fortunately it was only a practice session.

I believe the club has long since closed its doors.

The night before the 438 game …